Survey (ABS) collected from January through March 2015 to shed light on how the public views cleavages in Myanmar society. The aim is twofold: to describe some of the empirical findings of the ABS related to conflict as well as to offer an alternative understanding of conflict drawing from a different data source — ordinary Myanmar citizens.

The chapter examines public views of conflict generally and analyses how different groups in Myanmar society view conflict. Specifically, it concentrates on two different forms of political identity in Myanmar — ethnicity and religion — and examines the implications of responses to the ABS for understanding the causes and trajectories of conflict associated with these identities. Both cleavages are seen as underlying serious divides in Myanmar; ethnic differences have underscored decades of civil war and continued fighting between the Bamar majority and ethnic minorities, especially those concentrated in the states along Myanmar's borders.[1] Religious differences, notably between the Buddhist majority and Muslim minority, have contributed to religious riots, hate speech, and religious intolerance in recent years (Cheesman and Htoo Kyaw Win 2015; Schissler, Walton, and Phyu Phyu Thi 2015). These divisions have been at the heart of conflict and violence in Myanmar.

By looking at public perceptions of conflict around salient political identities, as well as views related to conflict in general and by minorities, this chapter offers some surprising insights. While the ABS confirms the seriousness of division in Myanmar society, the findings suggest there is considerable common ground across communities for peace building and to reduce tensions. Further, by bringing attention to the views of ordinary citizens, this chapter highlights the need to look beyond elite-oriented studies of conflict in understanding both current dynamics and future trajectories.

MYANMAR ASIAN BAROMETER SURVEY: METHODOLOGY AND FIELDWORK

The 2015 Myanmar ABS survey comprised over 200 questions, including the core questions in the Global Barometer and ABS surveys that allow for cross-regional comparisons, as well as specific questions directly related to Myanmar.[2] The main topics explored ranged from perceptions of governance, trust in institutions and social capital to political culture, partisanship and